Gentle Hands with Grown-Ups

Teacher Guide · Topic 8 of 12 · Value: Safe





At a glance	
Goal	Students keep grown-ups safe when they feel mad, especially when a grown-up says “no” or “not now”: hands down, step back, take a slow breath, and use their words. Mad is okay; hurting is not.
Time	15 minutes in Morning Meeting, in place of the general lesson. Centers run during the week.
When	Teach after Topic 7, Gentle Hands with Friends. Teach it on a calm day, never the morning after a student hurt an adult.
In the bundle	Student deck (7 slides, press N for notes) · Poster (letter and 11×17) · Center kit (sort, sequence, act it out, desk strips, coloring) · Mini book · Family half-sheet
Words we use	“Hands down. Step back. Breathe. Use my words.” · “I feel mad.” · “Mad is okay. Hurting is not.”

Before you teach

- Plan a two-minute warning for every transition this week. Most of these moments start when an activity ends without warning.
- Practice your own calm response first: a low, slow voice and few words. The adult response is the intervention.
- Hang the poster at child height near your meeting space or the transition spot students see before clean-up.
- Decide the yes you can offer when the answer is no, such as “Let’s take a picture of your tower” or “You can finish after lunch.”
- Tape a desk strip at the table of any student who has hit, kicked, or grabbed an adult.
- Pair students who need support with a steady turn-and-talk partner before the lesson starts.

The lesson, slide by slide

The same script is in the deck’s presenter notes. Press N while presenting.

Slide	Say and do	Look for	Engagement move

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Practice bridges for slide 5

Students model, not the teacher. The teacher narrates and asks the class what they saw.

If the model is...	Say
Excellent	“Show us again. Everyone, watch his hands stay down even with a mad face.”
Partly right	“Your hands stayed down. Now use your words: I feel mad. Try again.”
Silly	“Thank you. Let’s see it the safe way.” Call a new student. No commentary.

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Centers

Print one kit per group. Laminate the mats and cards so they last. Students work in groups of 2 to 4.

Center	Set up	Read to students	Done looks like
Sort It	Sort mat (landscape page) and 8 cut picture cards.	"Look at each picture. Is this friend keeping the grown-up safe? Put it on the side where it goes."	4 cards on Safe, 4 on Not safe. Accept any sort a student can explain.
Put It in Order	Sequencing mat and 4 cut cards.	"Put Tee's story in order: first, next, then, last. Tell your partner the story."	Students retell: clean-up time, hands down, I feel mad, we are okay.
Act It Out	4 role-play cards in a stack.	"Pick a card. Read it with me. Show me how you keep your grown-up safe."	Each student shows hands down, a step back, a breath, and the words "I feel mad."
Safe With Grown-Ups Steps	Desk strips, one per student.	"Point to each step and say it."	Each student says all four steps.
Color	Coloring page and crayons.	"Color Tee and his teacher. Then show your safe hands."	A colored page and hands pressed down.

Answer keys

- **Sort, Safe:** Tee puts his hands down · Tee takes a slow breath · Tee tells his teacher he feels mad · Tee and his teacher fist bump.
- **Sort, Not safe:** Diego with fists at the teacher · Malik pulls the teacher's sleeve · Sofia grabs the teacher's clipboard · Kiara pushes the teacher's hand away.
- **Put It in Order:** 1 The teacher says clean-up time · 2 Tee puts his hands down · 3 Tee says, "I feel mad" · 4 Tee and his teacher are okay.

The mini book (one child, Tier 2)

- For a child who has hit, kicked, grabbed, or pushed an adult. Read it one-on-one at a calm time, before the hardest part of the day.
- Read it every day for a week. Practice each step as you read it, especially the words "I feel mad."
- Never read it as a consequence or right after an incident.
- On the back, the child colors a star each day they keep grown-ups safe. Celebrate every star.

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When a student hurts a grown-up

Follows the Responsive Behavior Plan: the adult response is the intervention. Fewer words as escalation rises.

1. **Safety first.** Step back out of reach, keep your voice low and slow, and keep other students safe. Call for support if needed.
2. **Fewer words.** “You are mad. Hands down. I will wait.” Do not lecture or argue in the moment.
3. **Offer the steps.** Point to the desk strip or poster: hands down, step back, breathe, words.
4. **Repair later.** When the child is calm, use Topic 6, Fixing It: “What happened? How can we make it right?” Then start fresh.
5. **Do not take it personally.** The child is protecting something and does not have a safer way yet. This lesson gives them one.

Next in the toolkit: Topic 9, Things Stay Safe.

Family connection

- Send the family half-sheet home the day you teach. It is in English, Spanish, and Haitian Creole.

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